

How Communities Stop Destructive Development Projects — and How to Use This Map

A starting guide to the subject, and to this map. Read it before the country guides.

What this map is

This is a research toolkit for people fighting a road, mine, pipeline, dam, logging concession, or development that threatens a place they live. It plots three things:

- **Live projects** — real proposed and under-construction projects, pulled from official permit and assessment records, shown as green dots.
- **Research sources** — the public databases and watchdog organisations you can use to investigate a project, grouped by what you need to find out, for every jurisdiction where they exist: national, state, county, municipal.
- **Country guides** — for a growing list of countries, a step-by-step guide tuned to that country's laws, opened from the country's popup with the green ► **Community Resistance How-To** button.

The map does not run a campaign for you. It answers the question that stalls most communities at the start: what is this project, who is behind it, what is wrong with it, and who can help — and where are the records that prove it.

Communities win this fight

They win often enough that the moves are worth learning. A national vote in Bulgaria banned fracking. An island community in the Solomons had a bauxite mine that would have taken 60% of their home refused, and the company's appeal dismissed. Belize banned offshore oil to protect its reef. Kyrgyz protesters banned a whole uranium industry in weeks. Croatians stopped an underground plant that would have flooded a cave and threatened Dubrovnik's drinking water. Slovenians struck down a law opening their rivers to developers. Madagascar farmers drove a foreign gold miner off their land.

The campaigns differ, but the winners tend to do the same five things: find the decision while it can still be changed, pull the documents that expose its flaws, build a coalition the developer can't split, use the law and the overseers, and win the public. This map is arranged around those five moves.

How a project gets built, and where you can stop it

A destructive project runs through the same stages almost everywhere. Each is a place to intervene.

The permit. The project needs permission from some authority. A permit still **in review** can be shaped or refused; one already **permitted** is a harder fight. The Live projects layer marks which is which.

The environmental study. Significant projects need an impact assessment, usually with a public-comment window. The proponent writes the study to make the project look acceptable, but it has to concede the impacts and describe how it will manage them — and its gaps and admissions are the strongest evidence against the project. The map points you to the official register where the study lives.

The land, the money, the company. Behind the project sit an owner, financiers, the land it needs, and the officials who decide. Who owns the company and the land, where the money comes from, and who profits are all public-record questions the map groups by exactly those terms.

The local authority. Planning applications, agendas, hearing notices, and permit files usually appear on the town hall's own website first, before any national database. The map's facility dots put those offices on the screen.

The courts and overseers. Courts, audit institutions, ombudsman offices, and environmental tribunals can review a decision, and several accept citizen petitions that force an investigation. The map's court and oversight databases hold the precedent and the petition routes.

Realistic odds

Numbers vary by country and project; these are rough patterns, not promises. What raises the odds is consistent: acting while a decision is open, finding a real flaw, building a united public, and pressing several levers at once.

Situation	Rough chance of a stop, delay, or conditions
Filing alone, in an open window	20-45%
Exposing a real flaw in the assessment	30-55%
Following the money / land / owners	25-50%
Legal or oversight challenge	25-50%
Pressing a financier to withdraw	30-55%
All of it together, decision still open	45-70%
All of it together, decision already made	15-40%

Against a firm, well-backed project the realistic win is often scrutiny, conditions, and delay rather than a clean stop. Almost everything the map points to is free.

Using the map

Aim it: the goal selector and the lens pills

Two controls point the map at what you need.

At the top of the right-hand panel is the goal selector, "**What are you trying to do?**" Pick a goal and the map dims everything else and surfaces the databases that answer it, with a hint line telling you what you're looking at. Below it are the **Lens pills** — eleven categories — which do the same by drawer, for when you already know the tool. Use the goal selector when you have a question; use the pills when you know where the answer lives.

The goals, in the order an investigation usually needs them:

- **Find the official file / permit for a project** — permit portals, EIA registers, project trackers. Pull the application, the study, the correspondence.
- **Get the environmental study & a polluter's record** — pollution-monitoring databases (dated water and air readings, your baseline) and the company's violation history.
- **Request government records (FOI)** — who may file, how, and the response clock. Request the full file; keep the receipt.
- **Find out who owns the land** — property and tax registries. Look up the parcels, the owners, what they paid, and when each changed hands.
- **See who is really behind the company** — corporate registries: directors, parent, beneficial owners.
- **Check if money influenced the decision** — campaign-finance registers. Search the deciding officials against the developer and its directors.
- **See who won the public contracts** — procurement databases: the builders, the amounts, and any debarment list.
- **Identify the officials & decision-makers** — who represents the area and who sits where. These become the addressees of your letters.
- **Find past court cases & precedent** — case-law databases, plus the oversight bodies (audit, ombudsman, tribunals) and how to petition them.
- **Monitor a site from above / over time** — satellite tools to catch early clearing, compare imagery by date, and archive pages before they change.
- **Find watchdogs, journalists & allies** — the organisations and newsrooms covering this beat where you are; each says what it takes on.

Read a source

Clicking a country zooms in, and regions with sources light up. Click a region to open its list, and drill down through its sub-divisions — state, county, municipal — since property, court, and permit records are often held locally. Entries come grouped by lens, in labelled pull-downs with counts. Open one and its card says what it **can** get you, what it **can't**, and what it's **for** in a fight; "**Visit source ↗**" opens the database. Read the can't line first — it stops you searching the wrong drawer. Every link is a live official database, watchdog, or newsroom.

The Live projects layer

Tick **Live projects to resist** in the right-hand panel. Use the project search box to type a project's name, or just zoom to your area. Filter down the rows: **Project scale** (All / Medium / Large / Largest), then **Permit phase** — click off **Permitted**

to leave only the undecided projects.

Click a green dot and the popup gives you a deadline banner (with days left, if a comment window is open), the name, type, and status, the filed date, the company, and the scale; **Open source** → to the official record; and a **Dig deeper** row — a ready News search on this project, a Web search, an Area map, and the country's environmental register. On OpenStreetMap dots, a live box fills in with operator, developer, construction type, and dates.

Facility dots, gold markers, and the Wire

Zoom in far enough and **facility dots** switch on. The **town-hall** and **government-office** dots give you each office's website — where local planning files usually appear first — and they're your meeting and petition-delivery addresses later.

Gold markers are international bodies — development banks, environmental and human-rights tribunals, cross-border watchdog networks. Click one when a financier or tribunal is part of your fight.

The **Wire**, in the top bar, streams live resistance news — for framing, and for finding who is fighting projects like yours now.

Worked example: a plant appears upstream

You rent a house in a valley town. A neighbour mentions a battery plant proposed two kilometres upstream. Here is the run on the map.

Orient. Left: *How to use this map* and the *Index*. Right: the control panel — goal selector, Lens pills, filters, Live projects — and the legend. Coloured countries have research sources; green dots are real projects.

Find the dot. Tick Live projects, search the plant's name (or zoom to the valley), and click off **Permitted** to see what's still open. Click the green dot on the stream above your town.

Read the popup. Name, type, status, filed date, company, scale, the deadline banner, **Open source** →, and the Dig deeper searches. Ten minutes in, you know what's proposed, by whom, at what stage, and how many days are left.

Pull the file. Goal selector → *Find the official file / permit*. Open your region, download the application and the environmental study, and read the study for its gaps — a skipped seasonal survey, a "noise may temporarily exceed standards."

Get the baseline. Goal selector → *Get the environmental study & a polluter's record*. The monitoring databases hold dated water and air readings — your before picture — and the company's violations elsewhere.

Check the town hall. Zoom in for the facility dots; the town-hall site often posts the planning application, agendas, and hearing dates before the national register.

Follow the land and the company. *Find out who owns the land* — did parcels sell to an unknown buyer just before the announcement? *See who is really behind the company* — directors, parent, owners. *Check if money influenced the decision* — donations to the deciding officials.

Find the precedent and the overseers. *Find past court cases & precedent* — search "battery plant," the statute, the company; a past ruling that annulled an approval for the same skipped survey is what your lawyer needs on day one. The same lens lists ombudsman and tribunal petition routes.

Find allies and file. *Find watchdogs, journalists & allies*, and check the Wire. Then open your country's ► **Community Resistance How-To** for the local comment template, attach your baseline and the study's admissions, and file before the deadline. Keep the receipt.

The five moves

1. Find the target. Name the project, its stage, its deadline, its threat, and its flaw. (Live projects layer.)

2. Document it. Pull the file, the study, the baseline, the ownership, and the money. The developer's own study is your best evidence. (The research goals.)

3. Build the coalition. Bring in neighbours, the wider public, experts, watchdogs, and journalists. Guard against the split the developer will offer — jobs, money — to divide you. (Watchdog listings, the Wire, town-hall venues.)

4. Use the law. File in the open window first; it puts you on the record and preserves your standing. Then the flaw, the precedent, the oversight petition, and — where the project needs a loan — the financier. (Court and oversight databases, gold markers, your country guide.)

5. Win the public. Coverage raises the cost of the project and reaches the deciders. Lead with one verified fact and the deadline. (News searches, watchdog and newsroom listings, the Wire.)

Run them together, not in order. Documentation feeds the legal case and the press at once; a filing is a headline; a headline draws allies.

If you have little time

1. Tick **Live projects**, find your project, click off Permitted, and open the dot for the deadline.
2. Goal selector → *Find the official file / permit*; download and read the environmental study.
3. File an objection in the open window; keep the receipt.
4. Goal selector → *See who is really behind the company* and *Find out who owns the land*.
5. Goal selector → *Find watchdogs, journalists & allies*; check the Wire.
6. Open your country's ► **Community Resistance How-To** for the local levers.
7. Send one reporter your strongest fact and the deadline.

The first three alone — the project, the file, the filing — put you ahead of most campaigns.

When the system is tilted or captured

Decisions get rushed before the public knows. Studies get accepted with obvious gaps. Officials sit close to developers, and jobs are dangled to split communities. Enforcement is weak, and some wins get reversed when the politics turn.

Watch for the signs of a rigged decision: a rushed approval, a permit granted against the evidence, a contract steered to a connected firm, a donation to the deciders the year before the vote, a land purchase by an unknown buyer just before the announcement. One anomaly may be error; a pattern is capture.

When that is what you face, stop trying to persuade the captured decider and expose them instead. The map turns rumour into sourced fact: the land registry shows the purchase timeline, the corporate registry shows the real buyer, the campaign-finance register shows the donations, the procurement database shows the steered contract. Take those facts to the audiences that can't be captured — the courts, the oversight bodies and their citizen petitions, the financiers bound by their own standards, the watchdogs, the press, and the public.

Even on a tilted field, the basic moves work, just harder: a filing on the record, an exposed flaw, a traced payment, a united public, a documented record that outlasts the decision. Where a clean stop is out of reach, aim for conditions, scrutiny, delay, and a record ready for the next round.

Letters and filings

Keep copies and log every one; a filed objection or a demanded record is itself evidence. These are country-neutral skeletons — your country guide sharpens them to local law. Fill the brackets from what the map gave you.

Objection, in an open window — to the permitting authority: "As people affected by [project] at [location], we object. Grounds, with evidence: it threatens [water/air/land/health]; the study is deficient — [the missing survey]; [the consultation was inadequate]. We request refusal or strict conditions, and a formal answer." File before the deadline.

Records request (FOI) — to the records office: "Under [law], we request the full project file for [project], including the application, the study and annexes, all permits, and all correspondence with [company]. Please confirm receipt and the response date."

To an official — "We are residents of [place] writing about [project], which threatens [stake]. Our concerns, with evidence: [two or three]. We ask you to [refuse/condition/investigate] it, and welcome a meeting."

To a financier — "The project you are [financing] at [location] faces [a deficient study / a legal challenge / strong opposition] and may breach your environmental standards. We ask you to withhold or withdraw financing, and can share our evidence."

To a reporter — "Records show [quantified finding] on [project], with a comment window closing [date]. Specific, verified, local. I can share the file and connect you with residents. Can we talk this week?"

The country guide has the rest — the oversight petition, the letter to a company, the public statement — tuned to your jurisdiction.

Where to go next

This guide covers the subject and the map. The specifics — which body hears an appeal, how many signatures force a referendum, what a comment must contain, which lever is strongest where you are — differ by country, and getting them wrong wastes effort. Click your country on the map and open its ► **Community Resistance How-To** for those answers. Use the two together: this guide for the moves, the country guide for how to make them where you live.

Start now: find your project, pull the file, and file before the window closes.